

Hijacked by a salesman

LivePerson Inc offers customer service chat solutions for some 3,000 Web sites. It is now pushing a technology it calls Proactive chat to engage online shoppers upon arrival.

"I'm a live rep here to answer questions and offer promotions," says Cole when you first visit *TechnoScout.com*. "What product did you wish to chat about today?" *TechnoScout.com* is one of the first

e-commerce sites to try Proactive chat. As soon as you enter the site, the salesbot asks you what you need help with. It then directs you to the product or tells if the site does not stock the particular item. The salesbot can even get

you attractive discounts.

One of the biggest e-commerce firms, *eBay*, has signed a deal with LivePerson to help surfers register bids. Instant communication and problem resolution is appealing both to Web sites and their users.

Quite contrary to LivePerson's claim, Esteban Kolksy, a Gartner analyst, described Proactive chat as "one of the most annoying experiences of my life. When you do proactive chat, you don't know what the person is looking for, you just get in their faces".



Macworld Expo 2002

The largest convention for Mac-addicts, the Macworld Expo was held on July 17 in New York. Apple showed off some new gadgets and added new features to some old ones—their iPod audio player now works with Windows. Also unveiled was the new high-end Mac with a 17-inch monitor. Enhancements in Mac OS X include an improved address book and increased interoperability between the computer and cell phones. But there's some bad news for Mac aficionados—they will now have to pay for the .mac e-mail address and Internet storage.

snapshot

15 million
people expected to
share digital images
on the Net in 2002

Source: Gartner Dataquest

Go play outside!

A research study conducted by Akio Mori, a professor in Nihon University's College of Humanities and Sciences, links playing video games with reduction in mental faculties. The activity of the human brain can be associated with brain waves—



electrical signals that are sent out by the brain cells. Two such waves were used as pointers in this study—beta waves indicate liveliness and activity and alpha waves are emitted when resting. Mori analysed the brain waves of 240 people aged six to 29 years, and categorised the results according to the type of person being

studied. The first category consisted of people who rarely played video games and showed stronger emission of beta waves, implying an active mind. Those who spent between one and three hours each day playing games had roughly equal beta and alpha waves before each gaming session. However, once they started playing games, the beta activity rapidly decreased below the level of alpha activity. In those who spent between two and seven hours each day, beta activity was constantly near zero, even when they were not playing. "Many video games stir up tension and a feeling of fear, and there is concern that this could have an effect on the autonomic nerves," Mori said.

Interestingly, the study group did not play anything cerebral like *Civilization III*, or even a fairly strategic action-game like *CounterStrike*. Mori centered the study on Nintendo video games.



heroes

Gaming consoles

Console game sales received a very healthy boost when Sony Computer Entertainment America sold over 5,20,000 PlayStation 2s in June 2002 in the US and Canada. In similar vein, Microsoft's Xbox sold around 2,30,00 units and Nintendo's Gamecube console moved 1,12,300 pieces.

E-governance

The Madhya Pradesh government, along with Microsoft, is embarking on a project that aims to bring about various levels of e-governance in its different departments and operations.



zeroes

Online shopping

Joseph D'Amelio thought he'd found a great deal on eBay—a 2000 Porsche 911 for \$50,000. After talking to the seller and getting a copy of the car's confirmation sent to him in advance, he wired the money to an escrow company and fell victim to an elaborate scam. The seller had actually hijacked a legitimate eBay member's account and set up a fake escrow service.

P2P

American legislators are readying a bill that could sharply limit Americans' rights relating to copying music, taping TV shows and transferring files over the Internet. This could seriously cripple P2P services and could have an affect on other users worldwide.

■ Universal Music to put its library online ■ Panasonic will launch a drive to read multiple DVD formats ■ China threatens unlicensed Internet cafe owners